1 Background & Research Question

1. **From platform-access uncertainty to community encounters**

- The January 2025 influx into Xiaohongshu (RedNote) connected TikTok's US access controversy with international newcomers entering a China-based social platform.

2. **US–China media-system comparison**



Corporate prominence coexists with state intervention. Ownership requirements and regulatory decisions can affect commercial platforms' continued availability.

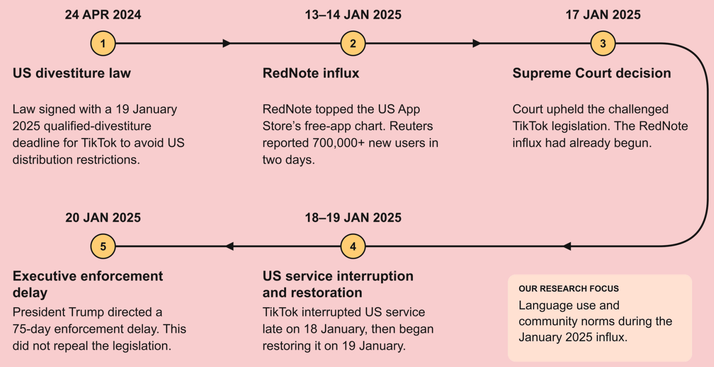


Commercial media development coexists with party-state authority and restrictions on many overseas platforms. RedNote nevertheless already connected Chinese-speaking communities across borders.

3. **Timeline: What happened & Why**

From access uncertainty to the RedNote influx

Key events: April 2024–January 2025



Sources: Public Law 118–50; US Supreme Court; AP; Reuters; Executive Order 14166.
700,000+ is a reported total with no nationality breakdown. US service dates use US time.

RESEARCH QUESTION

How did established RedNote users and international newcomers negotiate language use and community norms during the January 2025 influx?

2 Literature & Theoretical Framework

1. **Media-system context:** Hallin & Mancini (2004)

- Originally developed for Western news media, their framework compares media systems through dimensions including **media markets and state intervention**.
- We selectively adapt these dimensions to examine **platform ownership, commercial organisation and access** in the US–China background.

2. ***R*egional platforms:** Steinberg & Li (2017); Wang & Lobato (2019)

- Platforms' cross-border operations remain **situated in particular geographical, cultural and regulatory contexts.**
- We examine newcomers' encounters with **Chinese-language expectations and shared practices** within RedNote's existing platform community.

3. **Affordances**: Liu et al. (2026)

- Linguistic, social and technical resources offer **opportunities for communication and informal language learning**, depending on users' engagement.
- We analyse **translation features, peer advice and language explanations**, distinguishing support being offered from its observable use or acknowledgement.

4. **Digital place-making**: Xiao & Zhang (2026)

- Their study interprets TikTok refugees' migration through digital place-making, examining negotiations over **belonging, meaning and community boundaries**.
- We examine **Chinese-translation requests and conduct expectations**, focusing on how participants justify these expectations and respond to them.

5. **Informal community norms**: Xiong et al. (2025)

- Their study examines how users construct and contest an online community through **language negotiation, identity positioning and playful regulation**.
- We examine **cat-tax invitations, praise and symbolic** receipts to analyse how participation expectations are expressed, and contributions acknowledged.

Taken together, institutional and regional contexts frame the conditions of platform access and participation. Within this setting, we examine how users offer communication support, express and respond to participation expectations, and recognise contributions.

3 Research Methodology

Research design

- A qualitative case study of language use and community norms during the January 2025 RedNote influx.
- Literature, news reports and policy documents provide background.
- No interviews or surveys were conducted.

Materials and selection

- Screenshots of 5 public RedNote posts, captions and selected visible comments, collected on 3 October 2026.
- Purposive selection: relevance to the research question and sufficient context.
- Duplicate screenshots and bilingual display versions count as one case. Engagement figures provide context only.

RQ-guided close reading

- Each parent post provides context for analysing its caption and selected comment exchanges, including text, emoji and images.
- Analysis follows two themes: language negotiation and community norms.
- We examine translation advice, language explanations, Chinese-language expectations, conduct guidance and cat-tax participation.
- We distinguish offered support and stated expectations from visible responses and contributions.

Interpretation and limitations

- Identities are recorded as self-described; otherwise, participants are identified by observable roles.
- Selection prioritises assistance, guidance and shared practices and may underrepresent other experiences.
- Retrospective collection and incomplete comment visibility limit interpretation. Findings do not establish platform-wide patterns or lasting behavioural change.

TikTok Refugees on RedNote Language Use, Community Norms & Global Media

Sixuan Cao · Qixiang Zhang · Xiayan He · Qin Wang · Ziyu Guo
MECM20010 Understanding Global Media | University of Melbourne

Welcoming newcomers involved both helping them communicate and expressing expectations about participation in the selected exchanges

Findings

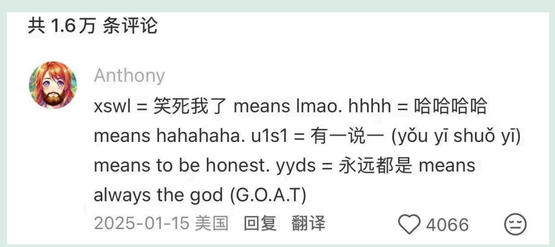
Finding 1: Language Negotiation

Language Support & Cultural Adaptation

- Users offered translation advice and reported using translation tools.
- Chinese users provide language guidance.
- Newcomers are encouraged to use Chinese.
- Communication involves support and adaptation.



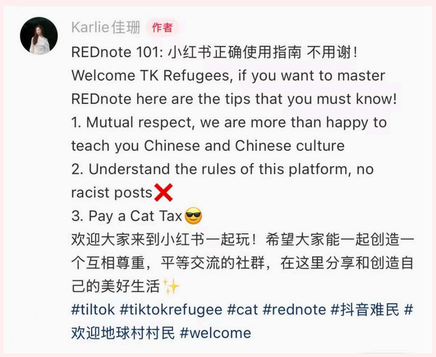
Language shapes cross-cultural participation.

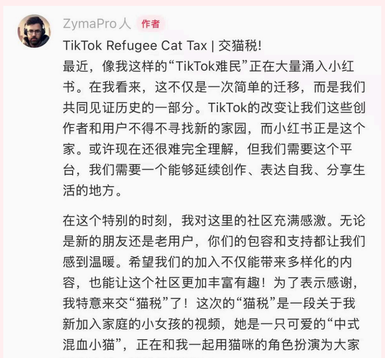


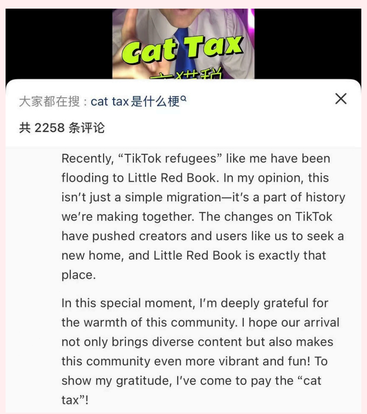
Finding 2: Community Norms

Mutual Respect & Cultural Participation

- Mutual respect shapes community expectations.
- Anti-racism expectations guide behaviour.
- "Cat Tax" encourages cultural participation.
- Shared practices help build community belonging.









Emerging Trends & Future of Global Media

Emerging Trend

Cross-Platform Migration & Cultural Negotiation

- Digital migration connects different cultures.
- Local platforms become global cultural spaces.
- Users actively reshape community norms.

Future of Global Media

More Connected, Yet Culturally Diverse

- More culturally diverse online communities.
- Greater need for cross-cultural understanding.
- Continued negotiation of language and cultural differences.

Key Takeaway: Global media is shaped by both platforms and the people who use them.

TikTok ⟷ 小红书

CONCLUSION

Global media does not simply connect people across borders. It also creates spaces where language, cultural differences, and community norms are continuously negotiated.